Bartosz Lewandowski
Department of Clinical Engineering
Academy of Silesia in Katowice, Katowice, Poland
bartosz.lewandowski@akademiaslaska.pl

November 10, 2026

Editorial Office
Foods (MDPI)

Dear Editor,

On behalf of all co-authors, I submit the manuscript entitled **"Reproducibility of Honey Taste and Odor Typicality Assessment: A Blind Consumer Panel Versus the Verdicts of Four Laboratories"** for consideration as a research article in *Foods*, section *Food Quality and Safety*.

Under Polish law, honey must have an odor and taste "typical of the given variety", and an organoleptic verdict of atypical taste can by itself lead to the rejection of a batch. Neither EU nor Polish law defines a reference for typicality, and the reproducibility of such verdicts is rarely tested. We assessed the same seven honey batches in a blind consumer panel (138 respondents, 966 ratings) and, in parallel, by four commercial and institutional laboratories, and we quantified the agreement at three levels: the panel as a rater, pairs of raters (laboratory–laboratory, consumer–consumer, consumer–laboratory), and the ability of a single rating to reproduce the laboratory verdict.

The main findings are:

- agreement among the four laboratories was fair on the binary scale ($\kappa = 0.30$) and slight on the three-level scale ($\kappa = 0.13$);
- a consumer agreed with a laboratory to the same degree as with another consumer ($\kappa = 0.10$ and 0.08), and a single consumer rating reproduced the laboratory majority verdict with AUC = 0.57;
- the panel and the laboratories agreed on the clearly typical sample, but not on the borderline ones.

These results bear directly on the use of organoleptic typicality as a stand-alone criterion in the official and commercial control of honey quality, a topic within the scope of *Foods*.

We confirm that this manuscript has not been published and is not under consideration for publication elsewhere, and that all authors have approved the manuscript and agree with its submission. The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Yours sincerely,

Bartosz Lewandowski
(corresponding author, on behalf of all authors)